

ALTERNATIVE METHODS FOR MANAGING PAIN

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Practice a program of recovery, including 12-step program participation and use of pain management skills.
2. Regulate pain without addictive medications.
3. Develop healthy options to cope with chronic pain.
4. Reduce daily suffering from pain and substance abuse.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE CHRONIC PAIN

- Alternatives to Addictive Behavior
- Assessing Self-Care Deficits
- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and Chronic Pain
- Coping with Addiction and Other Medical Problems
- Learning to Self-Soothe
- Physical and Emotional Self-Care
- Safe and Peaceful Place Meditation
- Use of Affirmations for Change
- Using My Support Network

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Medical Issues
- Opioid Dependence
- Substance Abuse/Dependence
- Substance-Induced Disorders
- Substance Intoxication/Withdrawal

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Alternative Methods for Managing Pain” activity is intended for clients suffering from severe and/or chronic pain who cannot use narcotics or other potentially addictive pain medications. The exercise offers several alternative approaches to managing pain and restoring quality of life without

running the risk of relapsing into addiction, which may accompany either using traditional pain medications or trying to “gut it out” and cope with the pain through willpower, thereby setting oneself up for relapse via self-medication. Follow-up may include assignments to investigate local service providers or support groups offering information or help with any of these methods, as well as investigation of online resources, including the support groups identified in the handout.

ALTERNATIVE METHODS FOR MANAGING PAIN

If you suffer from severe or chronic pain and need to find ways to manage it other than through the use of traditional pain medications, this exercise will help you find those ways, which you can use either instead of, or in addition to, the potentially addictive pain medications on which people usually rely. This exercise can be a useful companion to the other activities titled “Coping with Addiction and Chronic Pain” and “Coping with Addiction and Other Medical Issues.”

1. First, from what kind of chronic pain do you suffer, and how does it affect your daily life?

2. Please identify any professionals with whom you’re working to manage your pain.

Do those professionals know about your problems with addiction? _____ Are they experienced and qualified in working with people who suffer from addictions?

3. What methods of pain control other than medications have you tried?

If any of those methods have worked for you, which are they?

4. Here are some nonaddictive ways of managing pain. As part of this exercise, we ask that you talk with your therapist about each of these approaches, investigate whatever opportunities your community offers you to try them, and briefly write about what you find.

- a. *Over-the-counter (OTC) pain medications.* These are relatively mild pain-relieving drugs with no mind-altering effect. The best-known are the nonsteroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs); for example, aspirin, ibuprofen, and naproxen, and the non-NSAID drug acetaminophen. The difference is that, as the names imply, the NSAIDs reduce inflammation and pain, while acetaminophen reduces pain only. People using these medications need to be careful not to exceed safe dosages, as they can cause damage to the stomach lining and in large amounts can permanently damage the liver and/or kidneys, in extreme cases causing death.
- b. *Other non-mind-altering medications.* The best-known examples in this category are the medications for joint pain called Glucosamine chondroitin and MSM (methylsulfonylmethane). They work by helping the body's natural healing processes rebuild damaged cartilage and connective tissues. They won't provide immediate relief, but can be very helpful over time if taken consistently. Another category of pain-relieving medications that many people find helpful is those drugs that relieve the chronic pain of acid reflux and heartburn (e.g., antacids and related substances).
- c. *Topical (external) medications.* These are usually ointments that can provide relief for pain from musculoskeletal problems, including arthritis and joint injuries. They usually include analgesic (pain-relieving) ingredients, and some also have anti-inflammatory ingredients that reduce swelling and soreness. Some contain steroid compounds (a different type of steroids than the anabolic steroids sometimes abused by athletes). These steroids can have side effects including weight gain and weakening of the immune system, so it's best not to use them unless necessary, and not for too long.
- d. *Diet modifications.* Sometimes pain is caused by unhealthy elements in a person's diet. Gout is an example; cutting back on rich foods will often relieve this problem. Other problems may be due to food allergies—these can cause heartburn, headaches, and rashes, among other effects. As part of a thorough medical workup, you should ask for an allergy screening.
- e. *Acupuncture.* A standard procedure in Eastern medicine, acupuncture has been proven by extensive testing to give fast and effective relief of pain in many cases. If you use acupuncture, be sure you're working with a qualified professional.
- f. *Therapeutic massage.* This is another technique that, provided by trained professionals, can give quick and lasting relief for many cases of chronic musculoskeletal pain.
- g. *Hypnosis.* This is very effective for many people—as with other types of treatment, be sure you're working with a professional who has the right training, credentials, and experience.
- h. *Meditation.* Many pain sufferers find that meditation, especially using guided imagery, can help them detach from the pain they are feeling. Soothing music can increase the effectiveness of meditation; some studies have shown that people undergoing surgery respond better to anesthesia and recover more quickly afterward if they listen to soothing music before, during, and after surgery; music is also useful in other situations involving pain.
- i. *Stretching and progressive muscle relaxation.* The key in using these methods is to avoid pushing the stretch itself to a degree that causes pain or injury. This approach is particularly helpful with back and neck pain, as well as headaches.

- j. *Moderate cardiovascular exercise.* If you're able to exercise, you should find that 20 to 30 minutes of a moderate cardio workout (enough to make you sweat, but not to cause you shortness of breath) will relieve both physical pain and mental/emotional distress. This is because this kind of exercise increases the brain's endorphin and enkephaline levels (these are natural drugs, or neurotransmitters, that act as natural pain-relievers and mood elevators). Before you start any exercise program, be sure to talk with your doctor to make sure it is safe and to get his/her guidance on how to get the most benefit from your workouts.
 - k. *Laughter.* Hearty or prolonged laughter boosts the brain's levels of the same neuro-transmitters that cardiovascular exercise enhances, and affects physical pain and emotional distress the same way. As an added benefit, regular laughter strengthens your immune system, improving your resistance to illness.
 - l. *Pet therapy.* Spending time with an affectionate animal also provides some relief from physical and emotional distress, which is why hospitals often include pet therapy in their treatment offerings.
 - m. *Spiritual and/or religious activity.* Many people find relief in prayer and the company of people who share their spiritual beliefs; this can reduce the loneliness and feeling of isolation that often comes with intense pain, and can help a person make sense of an experience that can otherwise seem senseless.
 - n. *Participation in pain management support groups.* You may find practical advice and understanding from support groups organized for chronic pain sufferers. These include local, regional, and national organizations. You may be able to find them through local newspapers or magazines. There are also several national pain management groups you can contact online through these web sites (please keep in mind that as time passes, these sites may disappear and others appear—to get current information, we recommend using an Internet search engine such as Google.com).
 - (1) American Chronic Pain Association: www.theacpa.org
 - (2) Back Pain Support Group: www.backpainsupportgroup.com
 - (3) Chronic Pain Support Group: www.chronicpainsupport.org
 - (4) National Chronic Pain Outreach Association, Inc.: www.chronicpain.org
 - (5) Out of Pain: www.outofpain.com
5. Have you had any contact with a pain management support group, either local or online? If so, please identify the group(s) and briefly write about your experiences.

6. Please use this space to briefly describe your plan for coping with your chronic pain using non-addictive methods.

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.